

With just a couple of days to go to the event, here are some of the key event details for the Bark and Ride Sportive 2026 on Saturday morning. Please read carefully.

Event Start Times: The event will start at 9:20am following the safety briefing. The 125km group will start first, with a lead car in front and a broom wagon following. The 90km and 60km groups will leave together, directly afterwards and will each have a lead car in front and a broom wagon following.

Start and finish location: The event starts and finishes at the Connacht Hotel Galway (Eircode H91 K5DD). Please ensure you are at the start location at least 5 minutes prior to the start time for the safety briefing.

Parking: Parking is also available at the Connacht Hotel.

Toilet Facilities: We have access to the toilet facilities at the Connacht Hotel.

Event sign-on: Sign-on for the event will be available from 8:30am at the Connacht Hotel. Bring your Eventmaster registration ticket with you to the sign-on, where you will receive a wrist band which you need to wear for access to the food stations at the food stops and at the Connacht Hotel after the event finish.

Routes: The following are the Strava links for the routes.

- 125km - <https://www.strava.com/routes/3404957000265953318>
- 90km - <https://www.strava.com/routes/3404957502220169932>
- 60km - <https://www.strava.com/routes/3404957892583381030>

All 3 distances follow the same route initially **but note where the routes split** so that you don't end up on the wrong route. We will have marshals and signage at these points to help direct you but be aware of these splits:

60km/90km split: At 23km, just after the motorway flyover on the Kinvara road, the 90km route turns left while the 60km route continues straight on towards Kinvara.

90km/125km split: At 43km, the 125km route turns left towards Boston village, while the 90km route continues straight on.

Time cutoffs for 125km route:

In order to ensure the safe running of the sportive and to ensure that riders are adequately supported, the following time cutoffs will apply to the 125km route:

There is a time cutoff at 43km (Boston Village) for the 125km route at 11:30. If you are doing the 125km route and have not reached the Boston turnoff by 11:30, you will be asked to switch to the 90km route.

There is a further time cutoff at the Carron food stop at 56km. If you have not left this food stop by 12:30, you will be asked to turn around and head straight back down through Carron towards Corker Hill where you will rejoin the 125km route, just before Kinvara. This will reduce your overall distance by around 20km and get you back on track.

If you have exceeded the time cutoffs and decide to ignore the marshals' instructions to switch to a different route, note that you will be unsupported from this point onwards and the subsequent food stops may no longer be available once you reach them.

Safety: To help ensure your safety, we will have motorbike marshals supporting the event and assisting at junctions. We will also have support from An Garda Siochana at the start to help ensure that the groups get safely out of Galway city and through Oranmore. The sportive will be pace controlled until after Oranmore to help ensure that the group stays together and to minimize traffic disruption in the village. If you have already dropped off the back of the group by the time you reach the N67 junction at Oranmore, note that normal rules of the road apply and you should ensure that you stop at the T-junction and only turn right when it is safe to proceed. We will have static marshals at the junction to assist.

Please ensure you cycle no more than two abreast. On some of the narrower stretches, you may need to go into single file to allow approaching traffic to get by safely, so please ensure you give yourself sufficient space from the rider in front to enable you to react to traffic situations as they arise.

Junctions will either have static marshals or road signage (or both) to help you navigate the route. It is important to note that normal rules of the road apply. You need to stop at junctions unless the marshal has indicated it is safe to proceed. Note that marshals are not permitted to stop traffic. Their primary role is to help direct riders, so please listen and follow their instructions. Ultimately, you are responsible for your own safety so don't just follow the cyclist in front without checking that the way is clear.

While road surfaces on the route are generally good, watch out for occasional potholes and other issues such as loose gravel and shout these out to following cyclists. There is one section on the 125km route (from around 46km) where there is grass/moss in the middle of the road. Take extra care if crossing over and back. Also take care on this route on the descent after the Poul nabrone Dolmen as there are some sharp bends particularly as you approach the bottom of the descent.

Food stops: The main food stop for all routes will be at St Joseph's school in Kinvara, which is situated at 29km on the 60km route, 60km on the 90km route and at 95km on the 125km route. There will also be an additional water / snacks stop on the 125km route at Carron village (56km) as well as a stop at Kilmacduagh (38km) for the 90km and 125km routes.

What to bring: Ensure you bring a helmet, spare tubes, tyre levers, bike pump, bike lights, water bottles, mobile phone and some snacks/gels to keep you going. Based on the current weather forecast, it is likely you will encounter some light rain along the way, particularly later in the day. Check the weather forecast in the morning and dress appropriately for the conditions. It is always a good idea to bring an extra layer, just in case.

Litter. You are going to be cycling through a very scenic part of the country. Please ensure not to discard any food wrappers, gels, etc. Bring any rubbish to the food stops or back to the finish area.

Support vehicles: We will have a 'broom wagon' following the groups in case you encounter any issues.

Finish area: When you return to the finish at the Connacht Hotel after your cycle, you will be presented with your event medal along with a goodie bag to acknowledge your participation in the cycle. You will also be treated to a burger and chips, and we will have a massage area where you can avail of a free massage to help those weary legs recover. You can also avail of showers at the Connacht hotel. You just need to bring your own towel.

Emergency number: In the event of an emergency on the day, contact Kevin Quinn on 085-8159132. The emergency number will also be available on your wristband.

We hope you enjoy your cycle and thank you so much for supporting a very worthy cause.

We are incredibly grateful to our Main Sponsors for the 2026 Bark & Ride Sportive – **Aerogen and Nuark Construction** – whose generous support has been instrumental in helping us make this year's event possible.

We've also had great support from the local community and would like to especially acknowledge the support of the Connacht Hotel, An Garda Siochana, Bike Marshals Ireland, Arrigan Geo Surveyors, Barry & Byrne Kitchens, Carpet and Rug Centre Cleaning Machines, Corrib Oil, CPS Automation Services, Flynn's of Lackagh, Fahy's Garage, JP Cunningham Electrical, Kerrigan's Centra Kilcolgan, Topprint, The Musgrave Group, Optimum Nutrition, The Huntsman Inn, Nuasan, Galway Stone, Burke's Eurospar Kinvara, BPC Blossom Property Care, McCabe's Pharmacy (Kinvara), Runda Coffee, Walsh Heating & Plumbing, Dome Products and VMS LED Media Sign Hire for their very generous support.

In addition, we would like to thank Jimmy Keohane & Dave Hurley of Galway United FC, Galway Rose 2026 Jodie Kenny, former Galway hurler and New York dual star Johnny Glynn, and Connacht Rugby Coach Stuart Lancaster for their social media support.

A special thanks goes to Principal Dominic Gallagher & Secretary Hilary Sexton of St Joseph's school, Kinvara, for generously providing us with access to the excellent facilities there for the food stop.

We would also like to thank all of our volunteers and marshals for giving up their time to help out on the day.

On behalf of the Galway Branch Irish Guide Dogs and Challenge Cycling Club, we look forward to seeing you on Saturday.